



Brooklyn Bridge

A majestic bridge that was an engineering marvel in its time and steadily serves the commuters of New York

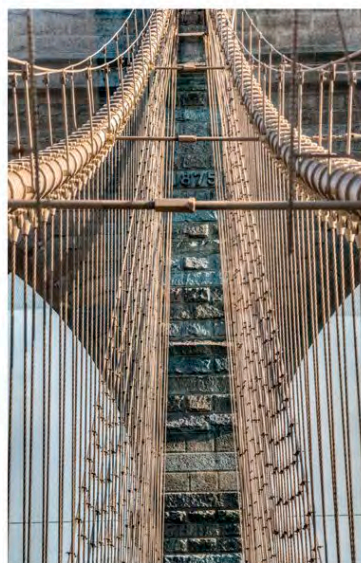
Brooklyn Bridge is by no means the longest or the tallest bridge in the US—although it was the longest, and first steel-wire, suspension bridge in the world when it was built—nor is it the most advanced. It is not even the only bridge that crosses New York's East River, but it can claim to be one of the most famous bridges in the world, as much an icon of its home city as the Statue of Liberty or the Empire State Building. The 5,989-ft- (1,825-m-) long bridge links Manhattan with its neighboring borough of Brooklyn.

Spanning the river

The idea of a bridge across the East River was conceived in 1852 by John Augustus Roebling (1806–1869), a German immigrant. Work began in 1869 under his son, Washington (1837–1926). While the finished bridge was technically a suspension bridge—one in which the deck is hung below suspension cables on vertical suspenders—it employed a hybrid cable-stayed design in which a fanlike pattern of cables also ran directly down from the two towers to support the main deck.

On May 24, 1883, the bridge was officially opened by President Chester A. Arthur, who crossed it together with New York's mayor Franklin Edison. The bridge was initially designed to carry horse-drawn and rail traffic, with a separate, elevated walkway in the center for pedestrians and cyclists. The last trains ran in 1944, and in 1950, the streetcars that shared the roadway also stopped. The bridge was then reconfigured to carry six lanes of cars. Height and weight restrictions keep commercial vehicles and buses off the bridge.

P. T. Barnum took the world-famous **Jumbo** and **21 other elephants** across the bridge in May **1884** to show that **it was safe**



△ CABLE POWER

The four main cables that support the roadway are each 3,578 ft (1,090 m) long and 15½ in (40 cm) wide, with each made up of 21,000 individual wires wrapped together.

▷ HAZARDOUS WORK

High up on a catwalk, two men survey the unfinished Brooklyn Bridge. Building the bridge was dangerous, with at least 20 workers killed during construction.

